🏭 Industry & the Progressives: Reading

US History · Unit 4 · Level 3 (closer to the class work) · goes with inventions, Boss Tweed cartoons, muckrakers, child labor, Triangle fire, Hull House

Name: _____

Muckrakers and Reformers

After the Civil War, new inventions such as Edison's light bulb (1879) and Bell's telephone (1876) helped American industry grow faster than ever. Business leaders like Andrew Carnegie (steel) and John D. Rockefeller (oil) built giant companies. Critics called them “robber barons” because they crushed competitors and paid workers little; supporters called them “captains of industry” because they built jobs and gave money to libraries and schools.

Cities grew too, and so did corruption. In New York, William “Boss” Tweed and the Tammany Hall political machine stole millions of dollars from the city. Cartoonist Thomas Nast drew Tweed as a greedy thief. Tweed complained that his voters could not read, but they could understand “them damned pictures.” Tweed was convicted in 1873.

Around 1900, reformers called Progressives believed the government should fix the problems of industrial life. Journalists known as muckrakers exposed these problems. Ida Tarbell revealed Standard Oil's unfair practices. Upton Sinclair's novel “The Jungle” (1906) described filthy, dangerous meatpacking plants. Within months, Congress passed the Meat Inspection Act and the Pure Food and Drug Act, which also forced makers of “medicines” to label ingredients such as alcohol and opium.

Child labor was another target. In 1900 nearly 2 million children worked in mills, mines and factories, often for 10 to 12 hours a day. Photographer Lewis Hine traveled the country taking pictures of “breaker boys” in coal mines and young girls at spinning machines. His photographs helped persuade states to pass child labor and school attendance laws.

On March 25, 1911, a fire broke out at the Triangle Shirtwaist Factory in New York. Exit doors had been locked, and 146 workers, mostly young immigrant women, died. The tragedy led New York to pass dozens of fire safety and labor laws. Frances Perkins, who witnessed the fire, later became the first woman in a president's cabinet. Meanwhile Jane Addams's Hull House in Chicago (1889) offered classes, child care and help to immigrant families.

Check your reading

1. Why were some business leaders called “robber barons”?

2. What two laws followed “The Jungle”?

3. How did the Triangle Fire change the law?